



2037 AGE GROUP · AGES 7-9 · FIRST-YEAR GOALIES

# BLUE CLAWS GOALIE SYSTEM

Full coaching reference. 11 drills · 4 pods · mastery ladder · 16-week map. Build a brave, talking goalie.

11

DRILLS

4

PODS

8

CARDS

16

WEEKS

STEP

ATTACK THE BALL

Step AT the shot; the “T” with the back foot happens on its own. Coach the attack, not the letter.

L1 · 3

MASTERY LADDER

L1 learning · L2 competent · L3 game-ready. Effort first; numbers only at L3.

TALK

COMMUNICATION COUNTS

Ball Top, Left, Right, Check, Break. A goalie who talks beats one with perfect feet.



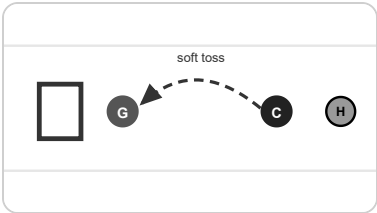
# TRACKING & NO-FLINCH

Brave eyes first — and hunt the rebound.

A1

## BUCKET TOSS TRACKING

Eyes lock on and follow the ball all the way in. Zero pressure.



### GOAL

- Skill: eyes track the ball through the catch
- Why: build tracking confidence early
- Watch: quiet head, no blinking, no turning away

### SETUP & BALL

Goalie kneels (no stick) 6–8 ft from coach. Coach underhand-tosses **tennis balls** to the hands/chest, announced every time.

### 2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** shags and refills the bucket, calls “TRACK IT!” every toss, swaps in as kneeling goalie every 10 reps. Nobody idle.

### BEGINNER

Soft tosses to the hands, announced. Catch two-handed and say “got it.”

### ADVANCED

Vary height; catch one-handed. On a miss, chase the loose ball and scoop it (first rebound hunt).

### MASTERY LADDER

|                   |                                                                       |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Keeps eyes on the ball through the catch, doesn’t turn his head away  |
| L2 · Competent    | Tracks and catches calmly without flinching, says “got it” on his own |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Catches ~8 of 10 while stepping to the ball, eyes never leave it      |

### COACHING CUES

EYES IN!

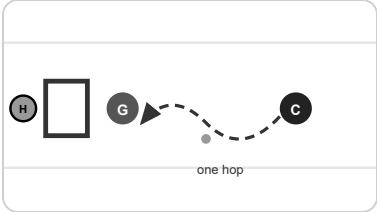
TRACK IT!

HUNT IT!

A2

## THE BOUNCE WALL

Get comfortable with a ball moving at him and reacting to a bounce.



### GOAL

- Skill: react to a moving, bouncing ball
- Why: comfort with a ball coming at the body
- Watch: steps to it, stick down, body stays square

### SETUP & BALL

Goalie in net with stick. Coach 10–12 ft out rolls/one-bounces a **Swax Lax** at the feet and lower body. Low and slow — stepping, not diving.

### 2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** stands behind the net as a “ball stopper” so misses don’t roll away. Rotate goalies every 8 shots.

### BEGINNER

Slow ground rolls at the feet. Step and trap, stick head down.

### ADVANCED

One-hop bounces to either side at moderate pace. Stick AND body behind it.

### MASTERY LADDER

|                   |                                                              |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Steps toward the ball instead of standing still              |
| L2 · Competent    | Stays square and traps low rolls without backing up          |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Handles one-hop bounces both sides, body behind it, ~7 of 10 |

### COACHING CUES

STICK DOWN!

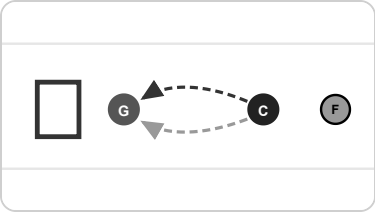
STEP & STOP!

STAY SQUARE!

A3

RAPID-FIRE HANDS

No-flinch reflex — get a stick up fast, repeatedly, eyes open.



GOAL

- Skill: quick hands, no-flinch reflex
- Why: kill the blink before it becomes a habit
- Watch: eyes stay open, resets between reps

SETUP & BALL

Goalie close, 6 ft, with stick. Coach rapid-tosses soft tennis balls to alternating sides. **Chest-height or lower at 6 ft** — a mask shot this close trains the blink.

2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** becomes the feeder, handing the coach two balls at a time so the pace never stops. Swap each round.

BEGINNER

3 tosses in a row, slow, announced “right... left... right.”

ADVANCED

5-6 unannounced rapid tosses. Head-height ONLY after backing to 10-12 ft. Reset to ready each time.

MASTERY LADDER

|                   |                                                             |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Gets the stick to most balls, eyes stay open                |
| L2 · Competent    | No flinch on rapid alternating tosses, resets to ready      |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Tracks 5-6 in a row eyes-open, calm hands, ~8 of 10 touched |

COACHING CUES

EYES OPEN!

HANDS UP!

RESET FAST!

B

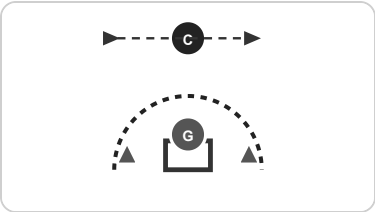
ARC & STEPPING

Attack the ball. The save is the feet.

B1

THE ARC WALK

Stay on the curved top of the crease — always between ball and net.



GOAL

- Skill: hold the crease arc, stay square
- Why: be in the right spot before the shot
- Watch: feet don't cross, stays square to the ball

SETUP & BALL

Lay 3-5 cones in a shallow arc across the top of the crease. No ball. Goalie shuffles cone to cone staying square to a coach walking side to side.

2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** stands at the far pipe and points to the coach, giving a target to stay square to. Rotate every 5 trips.

BEGINNER

Slow walk cone to cone, stick up, never crossing feet. Coach calls “left... right...”.

ADVANCED

Coach moves random and faster; shuffle to match, freeze square on the whistle. Remove cones.

MASTERY LADDER

|                   |                                                                    |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Shuffles cone to cone without crossing his feet                    |
| L2 · Competent    | Stays square to a slow-moving coach along the arc                  |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Matches a faster random-moving coach and freezes square on command |

COACHING CUES

TOP OF ARC!

DON'T CROSS!

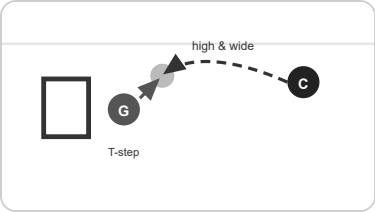
STAY SQUARE!

B2

STEP & ATTACK THE SHOT

STEP

Attack the ball — step toward the shot. The “T” happens on its own when he moves right.



GOAL

- Skill: aggressive step toward the ball
- Why: saves come from attacking, not reaching
- Watch: lead foot and hands go AT the ball, nose follows

SETUP & BALL

Goalie in ready stance. Coach 10 ft out calls a side, lobs a **Swax Lax** high and wide. Goalie **steps toward the ball** and drives the hands at it. The back foot forms a “T” naturally — don’t coach the T, coach the attack.

2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** drops a cone to the side the goalie should attack, giving a target. Swap shooter/goalie every 8 reps.

BEGINNER

Slow announced lobs to one side. Just step toward the ball, don’t reach from flat feet.

ADVANCED

Unannounced high/wide both sides. Hands lead, lead foot drives, save at full extension.

MASTERY LADDER

|                   |                                                                            |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Steps toward the ball instead of reaching from flat feet                   |
| L2 · Competent    | Attacks the shot with hands and lead foot on unannounced shots, squares up |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Drives to high/wide shots and saves ~half of them, nose to the ball        |

COACHING CUES

STEP TO THE BALL!

ATTACK THE SHOT!

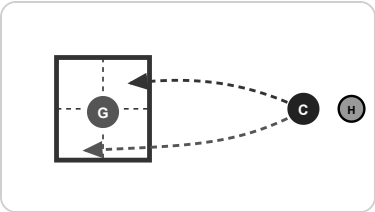
PUSH, DON'T REACH!

NOSE TO BALL!

B3

HIGH-LOW-SIDE REACTION

Match the right move to each of the four save zones, automatically.



GOAL

- Skill: pick the right move per save zone
- Why: the body learns where to go without thinking
- Watch: correct move per zone, resets to ready

SETUP & BALL

Goalie in net, stick up. Coach 12 ft out names a zone, tosses a **Swax Lax** there. Step up for high, drop hands for low, step to the ball for wide.

2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** calls the zone aloud a half-second before the coach throws, training ears and reaction. Rotate every 10 reps.

BEGINNER

One zone at a time, repeated. Master high, then low, then sides — separately.

ADVANCED

Random zones, no warning. Pick the correct move on the fly, reset to ready.

MASTERY LADDER

|                   |                                                              |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Makes the right move when the zone is called first           |
| L2 · Competent    | Picks the correct move on most unannounced single shots      |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Reads random zones and resets each time, right move ~7 of 10 |

COACHING CUES

MATCH THE ZONE!

HANDS LEAD!

BACK TO READY!



# SAVE, REBOUND & WIDE CLEAR

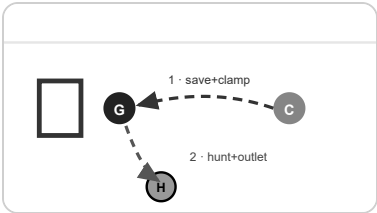
Finish the save and get it out wide.

C1

## SAVE, CLAMP & REBOUND HUNT

REBOUND

Secure it — and if it pops loose, attack the rebound instantly.



### GOAL

- Skill: secure the save, then hunt loose balls
- Why: the save isn't over until the ball is his
- Watch: clamps it, chases pop-loose, never admires the stop

### SETUP & BALL

Goalie in net. Coach lobs a soft **Swax Lax** to the stick — save, squeeze (clamp), cradle. Sometimes the coach throws one that **pops loose**; goalie chases the rebound and scoops it.

### 2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** stands 5 ft to the side as an outlet target; once secured/hunted, goalie tosses to the helper. Rotate every 8 reps.

### BEGINNER

Catch and freeze — hold the clamp two seconds, show the ball is secured.

### ADVANCED

Mix in pop-loose saves. React to the bounce, scoop the loose ball, then outlet.

### MASTERY LADDER

- |                   |                                                                       |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Makes the save and holds it (clamps) instead of dropping it           |
| L2 · Competent    | Reacts to a pop-loose ball and chases it instead of admiring the stop |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Secures or re-scoops ~7 of 10, then outlets, in a live rep            |

### COACHING CUES

SAVE & SQUEEZE!

HUNT THE REBOUND!

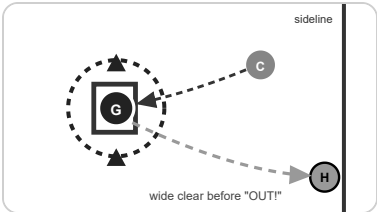
SCOOP & GO!

C2

## HOT POTATO WIDE CLEAR

WIDE

Save, beat the 4-second count, clear to the wide sideline alley.



### GOAL

- Skill: clear the crease fast and wide
- Why: a save is wasted if the ball stays in the kitchen
- Watch: feet leave the crease, ball goes wide not up the middle

### SETUP & BALL

Mark the crease with **cones**; outlet target out near the **sideline**. Coach feeds a **Swax Lax** save. Group counts “ONE-potato... OUT!” Save, step out, clear **wide to the sideline — never up the middle**.

### 2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** is the wide outlet AND the official counter — receives the clear by the sideline, rolls it back. Swap each round.

### BEGINNER

Slow count. Just: feet OUT of the crease, ball tossed to the wide side.

### ADVANCED

Real-tempo count. Clear the crease AND complete the wide sideline pass before “OUT.” Add a 2nd wide target.

### MASTERY LADDER

- |                   |                                                       |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Steps out of the crease after the save                |
| L2 · Competent    | Clears toward the wide side before the count ends     |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Beats the 4-count with a completed wide pass ~7 of 10 |

### COACHING CUES

HOT POTATO!

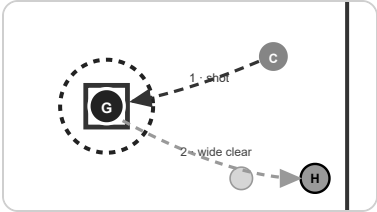
FEET OUT!

CLEAR IT WIDE!

C3

FULL PLAY LIVE REP

Everything at tempo: track, step, save, hunt, wide clear — one rep.



GOAL

- Skill: link the whole sequence at game speed
- Why: real reps tie all the pieces together
- Watch: completes each step in order under light pressure

SETUP & BALL

Full crease + sideline outlet. Coach takes a light, announced shot. **Real-ball gate: stay on Swax Lax until the goalie catches 8 of 10 without turning his head or closing his eyes** — only then a light real ball. When in doubt, stay soft.

2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** plays the outlet attacker breaking to open space near the sideline for the wide pass, then feeds back to the coach. Rotate goalies every 6 full reps.

BEGINNER

Announced medium Swax Lax straight on, one wide target. All steps in order — not speed.

ADVANCED

Light real-ball to varied zones. Read it, step, save, hunt any rebound, clear wide to a moving outlet.

MASTERY LADDER

|                   |                                                                       |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Completes save-then-clear in order, slowly, with help                 |
| L2 · Competent    | Strings track→save→clear together on his own on Swax Lax              |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Runs the full play on light real balls, ~half clean, talks through it |

COACHING CUES

SEE IT, STOP IT!

HUNT & CLEAR WIDE!

WHOLE PLAY!

D

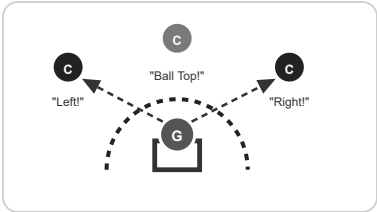
CREASE COMMAND & COMMUNICATION

A goalie who talks beats one who doesn't.

D1

BALL-TOP CALLER TALK

Learn the four basic location calls and say them loud, every time.



GOAL

- Skill: call the ball's location — Ball Top, Left, Right
- Why: a talking goalie is worth more than a quiet one at this age
- Watch: loud, confident, calls without being reminded

SETUP & BALL

No shots needed at first. Coach (or 2-3 helpers) holds a ball and moves around the top of the box. Goalie points and calls "**Ball Top!**", "**Left!**", "**Right!**" as the ball moves. Add "**Check!**" when the coach winds up.

2-PERSON

**Backup goalie / parent:** acts as a second/third 'attacker' moving the ball, and gives a thumbs-up every time the call is loud enough. Swap the talker every 1-2 minutes.

BEGINNER

Coach moves slowly; goalie calls the spot when prompted ("where's the ball?").

ADVANCED

Coach moves quickly between spots; goalie calls on his own, adds "Check!" on the wind-up.

MASTERY LADDER

|                   |                                                                |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1 · Introduction | Says "Ball Top!" and "Check!" when prompted by the coach       |
| L2 · Competent    | Calls Left / Right / Ball Top on his own as the ball moves     |
| L3 · Game Ready   | Talks through most of a moving drill loudly without being told |

COACHING CUES

BALL TOP!

LEFT! RIGHT!

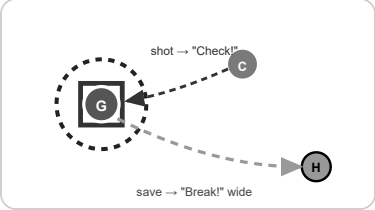
LOUD & PROUD!

D2

SAVE & SHOUT BREAK

TALK

Tie talking to the save — call the shot, then call the break.



- GOAL**
- Skill: communicate around the save (Check → One More → Break)
  - Why: links his voice to the action so talking becomes automatic
  - Watch: says "Check!" pre-shot and "Break!" after the save

**SETUP & BALL**

Light **Swax Lax** shots. Goalie calls **"Check!"** as the coach winds up, makes the save, then yells **"Break!"** and outlets wide. If a shot misses the net, he calls **"One More!"** to reset the defense.

**2-PERSON**

**Backup goalie / parent:** is the outlet who only moves when he HEARS "Break!" — so a quiet break gets no help. Teaches him the voice has a purpose. Rotate every 8 reps.

**BEGINNER**

Coach prompts each call. Save first, then add the "Break!" shout.

**ADVANCED**

Goalie runs the full Check → save → Break cycle on his own, adds "One More!" on misses.

| MASTERY LADDER |                |                                                                      |
|----------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| L1             | • Introduction | Shouts "Break!" after the save when reminded                         |
| L2             | • Competent    | Says "Check!" before and "Break!" after on most reps unprompted      |
| L3             | • Game Ready   | Talks the whole rep — Check, save, Break (and One More) — every time |

COACHING CUES

CHECK!ONE MORE!BREAK!

PRACTICE CARD REFERENCES

Grab one before practice. Each runs as a tight station. Combine 2 per session.

1

TRACKING

12-15 min

DRILLS

A1 + A3

FOCUS

Eyes on the ball, no flinch, quick hands

SUCCESS

Eyes-open through 5 rapid tosses (A3 L2)

2

FOOTWORK & STEPPING

12-15 min

DRILLS

B2 + B3

FOCUS

Attack the ball, lead foot drives, square up

SUCCESS

Steps to the ball unprompted (B2 L2)

3

ARC PLAY

10-12 min

DRILLS

B1 + B3

FOCUS

Hold the arc, stay square, don't cross feet

SUCCESS

Matches a moving coach, square (B1 L2)

4

HIGH SHOTS

10-12 min

DRILLS

B2 + B3 (high)

FOCUS

Hands lead up, drive to high/wide

SUCCESS

Saves ~half of high/wide drives (B2 L3)

5

LOW & BOUNCE SHOTS

10-12 min

DRILLS

A2 + B3 (low)

FOCUS

Stick down, body square, handle the hop

SUCCESS

Traps low/one-hop both sides (A2 L3)

6

REBOUNDS

10-12 min

DRILLS

C1

FOCUS

Clamp it, chase pop-loose, never admire

SUCCESS

Hunts the loose ball on his own (C1 L2)

7

CLEARING

12-15 min

DRILLS

C2 + C3

FOCUS

Feet out fast, clear wide, beat the count

SUCCESS

Wide pass before 'OUT' ~7/10 (C2 L3)

8

COMMUNICATION

8-10 min

DRILLS

D1 + D2

FOCUS

Loud calls: Ball Top/Left/Right/Check/Break

SUCCESS

Talks through a rep unprompted (D1/D2 L2-3)

16-WEEK SEASON MAP

Skills build in four phases. Cards refer to the references above.

| WK                                      | PRIMARY            | SECONDARY            | CARDS | BENCHMARK                                    |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------|----------------------|-------|----------------------------------------------|
| PHASE 1 - FOUNDATION (NO FEAR, THE ARC) |                    |                      |       |                                              |
| 1                                       | Tracking (A1)      | Arc intro (B1)       | 1, 3  | Eyes stay on the ball, no turning away       |
| 2                                       | Tracking (A2)      | Arc (B1)             | 1, 3  | Steps toward the ball, stays square          |
| 3                                       | No-flinch (A3)     | Arc (B1)             | 1, 3  | Eyes open through rapid tosses               |
| 4                                       | Stepping (B2)      | Tracking review (A2) | 2, 1  | Steps to the ball, doesn't reach flat-footed |
| PHASE 2 - STEPPING & SAVES              |                    |                      |       |                                              |
| 5                                       | Stepping (B2)      | High shots (B3)      | 2, 4  | Attacks the shot on unannounced reps         |
| 6                                       | High shots (B3)    | Stepping (B2)        | 4, 2  | Hands lead up on high/wide                   |
| 7                                       | Low/bounce (A2,B3) | Stepping (B2)        | 5, 2  | Stick down, handles the hop                  |
| 8                                       | Save & clamp (C1)  | Stepping (B2)        | 6, 2  | Holds the save (clamp), no drop              |
| PHASE 3 - REBOUNDS & CLEARING           |                    |                      |       |                                              |
| 9                                       | Rebounds (C1)      | Save review          | 6     | Chases pop-loose on his own                  |
| 10                                      | Rebounds (C1)      | Communication (D1)   | 6, 8  | Hunts rebound + says Ball Top/Left/Right     |
| 11                                      | Clearing (C2)      | Communication (D1)   | 7, 8  | Feet out, clears toward the wide side        |
| 12                                      | Clearing (C2)      | Communication (D2)   | 7, 8  | Wide pass before the count, shouts Break     |
| PHASE 4 - COMMUNICATION & GAME-READY    |                    |                      |       |                                              |

| WK | PRIMARY         | SECONDARY          | CARDS | BENCHMARK                                   |
|----|-----------------|--------------------|-------|---------------------------------------------|
| 13 | Full play (C3)  | Clearing (C2)      | 7     | Strings save→clear together on Swax Lax     |
| 14 | Full play (C3)  | Communication (D2) | 7, 8  | Talks the rep: Check → save → Break         |
| 15 | Game-ready (C3) | All cards rotate   | 1-8   | Real-ball gate passed (8/10 no-flinch)      |
| 16 | Game-ready (C3) | Communication (D2) | 7, 8  | Runs full play on light real balls, talking |

## PRACTICE SHAPE & BALL RULE

Kids hold focus ~3-4 min per activity. Keep blocks short.

**Each session:** gear check → tracking (4m) → footwork (4m) → save/clear or comm block (6m) → finish on a mini-game.

**Ball rule — earned, not assumed:** tennis ball → Swax Lax → real ball, only after the no-flinch gate (8 of 10 caught without turning his head or closing his eyes). When in doubt, stay soft.

## SOLO ENGAGEMENT GAMES

No backup goalie? He competes against a number. Under 5 minutes, always ends on a win.

### **BEAT YOUR NUMBER**

Races his own best — the only opponent is yesterday.

- 10 announced soft shots; count every ball he gets a body or stick on (touches count).
- That number is his “record” — write it on the stick tape.
- Beat it by one next time = team cheer.

### **DON'T WAKE THE DRAGON**

The net is a sleeping dragon's cave — keep it asleep.

- Starts with 5 “sleep” points; each save keeps the dragon asleep.
- A goal “wakes” it — lose a point with a fun roar so a goal is silly, not scary.
- Survive 8 shots with points left = tamed it. Then add a wide clear.

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Build the **brave kid** first, the goalie second. · Blue Claws Lacrosse · 2037 Age Group